

COLLECTION · QUÉBEC & LEGAL

Buying or Selling in Winter

*Myths and realities of winter real estate in
Quebec*

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It offers general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. As every real estate situation is different, it is recommended that you consult the appropriate professionals before making any decision regarding a real estate transaction.

© 2026 Émilie Cauvier — La Bibliothèque. All rights reserved. Any reproduction, distribution, sharing or resale, in whole or in part, by any means whatsoever, is strictly prohibited without prior written authorization. This guide is intended for the personal use of the purchaser.

Buying or Selling in Winter · Collection Québec & Legal · Guide No. 40 · 2026 Edition

Buying or Selling in Winter

Myths and realities of winter real estate in Quebec

“You shouldn't sell in winter.” Really? In Quebec, winter has its particularities — snow, cold, short days — but it also offers real opportunities, both for buying and selling. This guide separates myth from reality, season by season.

You'll see why winter buyers are often the most serious, how to present a property when everything is white, what advantages winter gives the buyer, and how to handle the practical aspects specific to the Quebec climate (snow removal, inspection under the snow, moving at -20°C).

Each chapter ends with a concrete tip. At the end, an action plan, a glossary and a quiz to anchor the essentials.

This guide's benchmarks apply to Greater Montréal: adapt them to your area and always validate your strategy with your broker according to market conditions at the time of acting.

CHAPTER

The myth of the “wrong season”

Nuancing a stubborn preconception.

There are generally fewer properties for sale and fewer buyers in winter. But “fewer” doesn't mean “bad”: it's often the opposite for those who know how to read the market.

The buyers who visit in January at -15°C aren't Sunday tourists: they have a real need (a job transfer, a separation, a growing family, a lease ending) and a tight schedule. On the other side, fewer sellers list, so your property faces **less direct competition** than at the height of spring.

What the season really changes:

- **Volume:** fewer listings and fewer active buyers.
- **Motivation:** the buyers present are more decided.
- **Competition:** fewer comparable properties listed at the same time as yours.
- **Timelines:** sometimes a bit longer, but with firmer offers.

Result: a good property, well prepared and above all **well priced**, can sell very well in winter — sometimes faster than an overpriced one drowned in the spring supply.

EMILIE'S TIP

Don't postpone a sale just “because it's winter”. A buyer who comes out in a storm is a motivated buyer. Fewer visitors, but a far higher rate of seriousness: it's often a winning trade-off for the seller.

CHAPTER

Selling in winter: presenting well

Offsetting the season's challenges, point by point.

Winter calls for a few presentation adjustments, all easy to master once you think of them. The goal: that the buyer forgets the cold the moment they step through the door.

Outside, the first impression plays out even before the entrance:

- Clear snow and ice from the entrance, the steps and the sidewalk before every visit — it's a matter of welcome *and* safety (liability).
- Clear the address plate, the porch and access to the shed or garage.
- Provide an absorbent mat and a space for boots at the entrance.

Inside, you sell comfort and warmth:

- Maximize the light (short days): curtains open, all the lamps on, warm-light bulbs.
- Heat to a welcoming temperature during visits.
- Showcase the energy efficiency: recent windows, insulation, a heat pump, a fireplace.

Finally, offset the absence of greenery: add to the file a few **summer photos** of the lot, the yard and the landscaping, so the buyer sees the property's full potential.

EMILIE'S TIP

In winter, sell a feeling: a warm, bright home that's easy to access despite the snow. And always show what the lot looks like in summer — that's what the buyer can't imagine under 40 cm of snow.

CHAPTER

Buying in winter: opportunities

Taking advantage on the buyer's side.

For the buyer, winter is often the best season — provided you know how to look. Two advantages combine: less competition and an inspection “in extreme conditions”.

Less competition, more power. With few active buyers, bidding wars are rarer and the sellers present are often in a hurry (a move already planned, a property already vacant, a double mortgage to avoid). Your room to negotiate widens.

The house shows its true colours. The cold reveals what summer hides. Use the visit to observe:

- Drafts at the windows and doors, a “cold wall” sensation.
- The efficiency and noise of the heating; ask for the **real costs** of the last 12 months.
- The presence of ice on the ground, ice dams on the roof or abundant icicles (a sign of deficient insulation or attic ventilation).
- The quality of the snow removal and access; how a sloped driveway behaves.

You thus test the property in its most demanding conditions — an inspection advantage the summer buyer will never have.

EMILIE'S TIP

Buying in winter means seeing the house at its worst: drafts, ice, the real heating bill. What you observe in January won't surprise you the following winter — and it gives you concrete arguments to negotiate.

CHAPTER

Each season has its logic

Choosing the timing by your priorities, not by prejudice.

Rather than a “good” or “bad” season, think in terms of trade-offs. Each period has its strengths and weaknesses, for the buyer as for the seller.

- **Spring:** the most active market. Lots of choice and buyers, clear lots — but strong competition and frequent bidding wars.
- **Summer:** a sustained market, exteriors and pools at their best; a slowdown during the construction holiday.
- **Fall:** serious buyers who want to settle in before winter; a short window before the slowdown.
- **Winter:** less volume, but reduced competition and highly motivated buyers.

The “best” moment therefore depends on your goal: **maximizing the number of buyers** (spring), **reducing competition** (winter), or simply **following your life calendar** (a transfer, a birth, retirement). A seller who wants little competition and a buyer who wants to negotiate can both do very well in January.

In every case, price and preparation weigh far more than the season. A well-priced, impeccable property sells in any season; an overpriced one lingers even in spring.

EMILIE'S TIP

Don't let the calendar decide for you. The real question isn't “is it the right season?” but “is it the right time for me, and is my price fair?” Those two answers count far more than the weather.

CHAPTER

Practical aspects of the Quebec winter

Anticipating the logistics specific to the climate.

In Quebec, winter adds concrete realities to the transaction. Well anticipated, they become simple organization rather than nasty surprises.

Inspection. Snow can hide the roof, the slope of the lot, the drainage, a slab crack or the state of the cladding. Ask the seller for summer photos, note these points at the inspection and, if needed, plan an additional check at the thaw.

Moving. Icy roads, short days and sub-zero temperatures complicate the logistics:

- Book early: good movers get scarce and July 1 isn't the only possible date.
- Protect floors and furniture from road salt and moisture (mats, reinforced boxes).
- Keep a margin in the schedule in case of a storm.

Taking possession. As soon as you get the keys, check that the heating works, that the water hasn't been shut off (risk of frozen pipes in a vacant unit) and that the access is cleared. Finally, make sure your **home insurance is in force** before the deep cold, including for a temporarily unoccupied property.

EMILIE'S TIP

You don't buy what you can't see. If the snow hides the roof and the lot, require summer photos and have it recorded at the inspection. And for any home left empty in winter: heating kept on and water monitored, otherwise a frozen pipe can cost a fortune.

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

Your next steps, concretely.

This week

1. Decide my strategy without a seasonal bias.
2. List the winter adjustments (snow removal, light).

Within 30 days

1. Prepare a warm, accessible presentation.
2. Take advantage of a less crowded market.

Next

1. Act according to my needs, not the calendar.

Depending on the season

1. Adapt my presentation (snow removal, light, warmth) if I sell in winter.
2. Take advantage of reduced competition and test the house in deep cold if I buy in winter.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Seasonality: the variation in market activity by season.
 - Motivated buyers: those who visit in winter, often more serious.
 - Winter curb appeal: cleared access and a warm presentation.
 - Winter test: observing insulation, heating and infiltration in deep cold.
 - Seller competition: lower in winter.
-
- Seasonality: the variation in market activity by season.
 - Motivated buyers: those who visit in winter, often more serious.
 - Winter curb appeal: cleared access and a warm presentation.
 - Winter test: observing insulation, heating and infiltration in deep cold.
 - Ice dam: a buildup of ice at the roof's edge, a sign of insulation/ventilation to check.
 - Winter possession: check heating, water and access as soon as you get the keys.

GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. In winter, there are generally:

- A) More properties and buyers
- B) Fewer of both, but more motivated buyers
- C) No transactions
- D) Zero prices

2. An advantage of selling in winter is:

- A) More competition
- B) Less competition between sellers
- C) No buyers
- D) Higher taxes

3. To sell well in winter, you must:

- A) Leave the ice
- B) Clear snow, maximize light and warmth
- C) Turn off the heating
- D) Close the curtains

4. To offset the short days, you should:

- A) Lower the blinds
- B) Maximize the light (curtains open, warm lighting)
- C) Visit at night
- D) Change nothing

5. Buying in winter lets you see:

- A) The garden in bloom
- B) How the house behaves in deep cold
- C) Nothing
- D) The pool open

6. Winter buyers are often:

- A) Mere onlookers
- B) More motivated and serious
- C) Non-existent
- D) Tourists

7. The “best” moment to transact:

- A) Is always spring
- B) Depends on your priorities and your situation
- C) Never exists
- D) Is set by law

8. Spring is characterized by:

- A) No buyers
- B) Lots of choice but strong competition
- C) Zero prices
- D) No properties

9. If snow hides the roof at the visit, you must:

- A) Ignore it
- B) Ask for summer photos and note it at the inspection
- C) Buy blindly
- D) Cancel the purchase

10. A winter move mainly requires:

- A) No preparation
- B) Planning a margin (roads, ice, delays)
- C) Moving at night
- D) Waiting for summer

Answer key

- 1. **B** — Fewer in number, more serious (ch. 1).
- 2. **B** — Reduced competition (ch. 1).
- 3. **B** — Comfort and access (ch. 2).
- 4. **B** — Maximize the light (ch. 2).
- 5. **B** — A test in demanding conditions (ch. 3).
- 6. **B** — Stronger motivation (ch. 1 and 3).
- 7. **B** — Each season has its logic (ch. 4).
- 8. **B** — High volume and competition (ch. 4).

9. **B** — Document what you can't see (ch. 5).

10. **B** — Anticipate the logistics (ch. 5).

Signé PAR Em

*Thank you for reading. May this guide help you
decide with confidence, with all the information
in hand.*

© 2026 Émilie Cauvier — La Bibliothèque. All rights reserved. Any reproduction, distribution, sharing or resale, in whole or in part, by any means whatsoever, is strictly prohibited without prior written authorization.
This guide is intended for the personal use of the purchaser.